
The Household Receipt Book

SEVENTY-FOUR SHORT RECEIPTS FOR THE MODERN FLAT

Each with its Proper Accompaniment · Compiled by a Lady of the Fourth Floor

The receipts that follow are brief, because the reader is busy, and honest, because the reader is clever. To each is appended the manner in which it is best enjoyed, for a dish taken in the wrong place or during the wrong pastime is only half a dish. The compiler has tested every pairing personally and regrets several.

🍷 BREADS & BAKES 🍷

SODA BREAD

Mix flour, a spoon of soda, and salt. Pour in buttermilk until a rough dough forms, shape into a round, cut a cross in the top, and bake hard and fast.

☞ *Best eaten while playing the guitar, badly.*

OAT BISCUITS

Rub butter into oats and flour, sweeten with brown sugar, bind with a little milk, and bake in small rounds until the edges darken.

☞ *Best eaten while sweeping the window sills.*

YORKSHIRE PUDDING

Beat eggs, flour, and milk into a thin batter and let it rest an hour. Pour into smoking-hot fat and do not open the oven door, whatever you hear.

☞ *Best eaten after looking under the couch cushions.*

BUTTERMILK SCONES

Cut cold butter into flour and a pinch of sugar, add buttermilk, and handle as little as possible. Bake tall and split while warm.

☞ *Best enjoyed while playing the piano with one hand.*

RYE CRACKERS

Roll rye flour, water, salt, and caraway very thin, prick all over with a fork, and bake until they snap.

☞ *Keep well in the sock drawer, wrapped in paper.*

CORNBREAD

Stir a cup of cornmeal into a cup of flour with a spoon of sugar, a pinch of salt, and a spoon of baking powder. Beat in an egg, a cup of milk, and a knob of melted butter. Bake in a hot, buttered tin until the top cracks and turns gold.

☞ *Best eaten while playing a game of backgammon.*

BANANA LOAF

Mash three tired bananas into butter and sugar, beat in an egg, fold in flour and soda, and bake slowly until a knife comes out clean.

☞ *Best eaten while browsing an important gene-editing database.*

CHEESE STRAWS

Roll pastry with grated hard cheese and a dust of mustard, cut into strips, twist, and bake until they crisp.

☞ *Best served warm from the top rack of the dishwasher, which will not work, but is worth trying.*

POTATO FARLS

Mash yesterday's potatoes with flour and butter, press flat, cut into quarters, and fry dry in a hot pan.

☞ *Best eaten under the stair railing.*

SEED CAKE

Cream butter and sugar, beat in eggs, fold in flour and a spoon of caraway seeds, and bake in a loaf tin for an hour.

☞ *Best eaten by the light of a bulb that needs changing.*

GRIDDLE CAKES

Whisk flour, milk, an egg, and a pinch of soda into a batter and spoon onto a hot griddle. Flip when the bubbles burst.

☞ *Best eaten while the laundry machine runs its last spin.*

GINGERBREAD

Melt butter with treacle and brown sugar, stir into flour, ginger, and soda, add an egg and milk, and bake until dark and springy.

☞ *Best eaten on the top shelf of the linen closet.*

🍷 SOUPS & STEWS 🍷

LEEK AND POTATO SOUP

Sweat sliced leeks in butter, add cubed potatoes and stock, simmer until soft, and mash roughly with a fork.

☞ *Best eaten straight from the toaster oven, standing up.*

SPLIT PEA SOUP

Soak peas overnight, then simmer with a ham bone, an onion, and a bay leaf until the peas collapse. Remove the bone and the bay leaf and keep the rest.

☞ *Best eaten beside the spice drawer, with the drawer open.*

TOMATO SOUP

Roast tomatoes and garlic until they blister, blend with stock and a splash of cream, and season generously.

☞ *Best eaten beside the plant that needs repotting.*

BEEF STEW

Brown cubed beef in batches, add onions, carrots, a spoon of flour, and stock, and cook low and slow until the beef gives up.

☞ *Best eaten while cleaning the paintbrushes.*

CHICKEN BROTH

Cover a chicken carcass with cold water, add an onion, celery, and peppercorns, and simmer gently for three hours. Strain and salt.

☞ *Best taken between sets of push-ups.*

FRENCH ONION SOUP

Cook sliced onions in butter for an hour until they are brown and sweet, add stock and a splash of wine, and top each bowl with toast and melted cheese.

☞ *Best eaten out of a cardboard box, sitting inside a larger cardboard box.*

LENTIL SOUP

Soften onion, carrot, and cumin in oil, add red lentils and stock, and simmer until thick. Finish with lemon.

☞ *Best eaten while losing at chess.*

MUSHROOM SOUP

Fry mushrooms hard in butter until they squeak, add thyme, stock, and cream, and blend until smooth.

☞ *Best eaten while singing your favourite song at full volume.*

FISH CHOWDER

Simmer potatoes and onion in milk, add chunks of white fish and a little bacon, and cook gently until the fish flakes.

☞ *Best eaten while playing the songs everyone knows.*

MINESTRONE

Cook beans, diced vegetables, and pasta in tomato stock until everything is tender, and stir in torn basil at the end.

☞ *Best eaten over a game of chess, with the board turned the wrong way round.*

PUMPKIN SOUP

Roast pumpkin with onion and sage, blend with stock, and add nutmeg and a swirl of cream.

☞ *Best eaten during a game of checkers.*

🍷 DISHES FOR THE EVENING 🍷

SHEPHERD'S PIE

Brown minced lamb with onion and carrot, add stock and a spoon of tomato paste, cover with mashed potato, and bake until the top browns.

☞ *Best eaten while losing at Scrabble.*

MACARONI CHEESE

Make a white sauce with butter, flour, and milk, melt in a great deal of cheese, stir through cooked macaroni, and bake until bubbling.

☞ *Best eaten while playing dominoes.*

ROAST CHICKEN

Rub a chicken with butter, salt, and thyme, put a lemon inside it, and roast until the legs wobble freely.

☞ *Best eaten during a hand of cribbage.*

TOAD IN THE HOLE

Brown sausages in a hot tin of fat, pour Yorkshire batter around them, and bake until the batter rises like a cliff.

☞ *Best eaten over a game of cards, any game, any cards.*

KEDGEREE

Poach smoked haddock in milk, flake into buttered rice with curry powder, and fold through chopped boiled eggs and parsley.

☞ *Best eaten while a tower of Jenga is being built.*

FISH PIE

Poach white fish and prawns in milk, make the milk into a sauce, combine, top with mash, and bake.

☞ *Best eaten while alphabetising the bookshelf.*

SAUSAGE AND MASH

Fry sausages slowly until sticky, mash potatoes with too much butter, and pour onion gravy over the lot.

☞ *Best eaten while finishing the crossword.*

VEGETABLE CURRY

Fry onion, ginger, and garlic with spices, add chopped vegetables, coconut milk, and chickpeas, and simmer until thick.

☞ *Best eaten during a game of Uno.*

BAKED BEANS ON TOAST

Warm beans with a spoon of brown sauce and a knob of butter, and pile onto thick buttered toast.

☞ *Best eaten while a game of Monopoly is being abandoned.*

BUBBLE AND SQUEAK

Fry leftover mashed potato and cabbage in a hot pan until a crust forms, flip, and repeat.

☞ *Best eaten in the bath.*

WELSH RAREBIT

Melt cheese with a spoon of mustard, a splash of ale, and an egg yolk, spread onto toast, and grill until it blisters.

☞ *Best eaten on the fire escape.*

PEA RISOTTO

Stir hot stock into rice and onion a ladle at a time, add peas and mint at the end, and finish with butter and cheese.

☞ *Best eaten under the kitchen table.*

LAMB CHOPS

Season chops, sear in a hot pan with rosemary, and rest them longer than seems reasonable.

☞ *Best eaten with the freezer door open, standing up.*

STUFFED PEPPERS

Fill halved peppers with cooked rice, tomato, herbs, and cheese, and bake until the edges char.

👉 *Best eaten standing in the pantry.*

OMELETTE

Beat three eggs with salt, pour into foaming butter, drag the edges toward the middle, and fold before it sets.

👉 *Best eaten while watering the plants.*

PORK AND APPLE

Sear pork chops, add sliced apples and a splash of cider, and simmer until the apples slump.

👉 *Best eaten in bed, with a towel underneath.*

MUSHROOM STROGANOFF

Fry mushrooms and onion, add paprika, stock, and sour cream, and serve over rice or noodles.

👉 *Best eaten with the curtains drawn.*

🍴 SIDES & SMALL THINGS 🍴

ROAST POTATOES

Parboil potatoes, shake them roughly in the pan, and roast in hot fat until they rattle.

👉 *Best eaten behind the bookshelf.*

BUTTERED CABBAGE

Shred cabbage, cook briefly in a little water, drain, and toss with butter and black pepper.

👉 *Best eaten from the bag of rice, which is not what the bag is for.*

PICKLED ONIONS

Salt small onions overnight, rinse, and cover with spiced vinegar in a jar for a month.

👉 *Best eaten nestled among the mixing bowls.*

DEVEILED EGGS

Halve boiled eggs, mash the yolks with mustard and mayonnaise, and pipe back into the whites with a dust of paprika.

👉 *Best eaten after checking the mailbox.*

CHEESE ON TOAST

Grate cheese, pile onto toast, and grill until it bubbles. Add Worcestershire sauce if you are that sort of person.

👉 *Best eaten next to the toaster, watching it.*

GARLIC BREAD

Mash butter with garlic and parsley, spread into slashes cut in a loaf, wrap in foil, and bake.

👉 *Best eaten atop a stepladder.*

POTATO SALAD

Boil waxy potatoes, cool, and dress with mayonnaise, chopped gherkins, and chives.

👉 *Best eaten in a coat closet, among the coats.*

COLESLAW

Shred cabbage and carrot finely and dress with mayonnaise, a little vinegar, and a pinch of sugar.

👉 *Best eaten on the balcony, whatever the weather.*

SAUTÉED GREENS

Wilt greens in olive oil with garlic and chilli, and finish with lemon.

👉 *Best eaten on the doormat.*

BAKED TOMATOES

Halve tomatoes, top with breadcrumbs, garlic, and oil, and bake until soft.

👉 *Best eaten under the cutting board, which is a strange place for it.*

CORN ON THE COB

Boil corn for five minutes, roll in butter, and salt heavily.

👉 *Best eaten while changing the bedsheets.*

CAULIFLOWER CHEESE

Boil cauliflower until just tender, cover with cheese sauce, and bake until the top browns.

👉 *Best eaten from the dishwasher, on the top rack, unwashed.*

HUMMUS

Blend chickpeas with tahini, lemon, garlic, and oil until smooth, thinning with cold water.

👉 *Best eaten after checking every coat pocket.*

WELSH CAKES

Rub butter into flour with sugar and currants, bind with an egg, roll, cut into rounds, and cook on a griddle.

👉 *Best eaten over a game of Coup, trusting nobody.*

🍦 SWEETS 🍦

APPLE CRUMBLE

Stew sliced apples with sugar, top with a rubble of flour, butter, and oats, and bake until the juices bubble through.

👉 *Best eaten under the bathroom sink.*

RICE PUDDING

Bake rice slowly in sweetened milk with nutmeg for two hours, stirring in the skin as it forms.

👉 *Best eaten with a scoop of protein powder, for reasons of science.*

BREAD AND BUTTER PUDDING

Layer buttered bread and raisins in a dish, pour over sweet egg custard, rest, and bake until set.

👉 *Best eaten under the rug.*

TREACLE TART

Warm golden syrup with breadcrumbs and lemon zest, pour into a pastry case, and bake until it just sets.

👉 *Best eaten with the hallway light off.*

LEMON CURD

Whisk eggs, sugar, butter, and lemon over a low heat until thick, and pot while warm.

☞ *Best eaten from the umbrella stand.*

SHORTBREAD

Work butter, sugar, and flour into a dough, press into a tin, prick, and bake pale.

☞ *Best eaten from the vegetable crisper.*

BAKED APPLES

Core apples, fill with brown sugar, butter, and raisins, and bake until they collapse.

☞ *Best eaten while looking in the medicine cabinet.*

CUSTARD

Warm milk, whisk into egg yolks and sugar, and return to the heat until it coats the back of a spoon.

☞ *Best eaten out of the freezer, before it has thawed.*

JAM ROLY-POLY

Roll suet pastry with jam, wrap in paper, and steam for two hours.

☞ *Best eaten while ironing.*

SPONGE CAKE

Beat equal weights of butter, sugar, eggs, and flour, and bake in two tins. Sandwich with jam and cream.

☞ *Best eaten while winding a clock.*

FLAPJACKS

Melt butter, sugar, and syrup, stir in oats, press into a tin, and bake until golden at the edges.

☞ *Best eaten with the television on and the sound off.*

STEWED RHUBARB

Cook rhubarb with sugar and a splash of water until it falls apart, and cool.

☞ *Best eaten with all the windows open.*

CHOCOLATE PUDDING

Melt chocolate with butter, fold into beaten eggs, sugar, and a spoon of flour, and bake in cups until the middle wobbles.

☞ *Best eaten while tuning a guitar.*

PANCAKES

Whisk flour, an egg, and milk into a thin batter and fry in butter. Lemon and sugar, no discussion.

☞ *Best eaten while waiting for the kettle.*

🍷 DRINKS 🍷

HOT CHOCOLATE

Melt dark chocolate into hot milk, whisk until frothy, and sweeten to taste.

☞ *Best drunk beneath the desk.*

GINGER TEA

Simmer sliced ginger in water for ten minutes, strain, and add honey and lemon.

☞ *Best drunk on the stairs, halfway up.*

LEMON BARLEY WATER

Simmer pearl barley in water, strain, and add lemon juice, zest, and sugar. Chill.

☞ *Best drunk in the shower, cold.*

MULLED CIDER

Warm cider gently with cinnamon, cloves, and orange peel. Do not boil.

☞ *Best drunk while checking the smoke alarm.*

ICED COFFEE

Brew strong coffee, cool it entirely, and pour over ice with milk.

☞ *Best drunk in the bicycle's shadow.*

EGG NOG

Beat egg yolks with sugar, add milk, cream, and nutmeg, and fold in whipped whites.

☞ *Best drunk while looking through the peephole.*